

Recovering Bones and Shell

Zooarchaeologists recover bone and shell from archaeological contexts through systematic sampling of an archaeological site. This may include a variety of sampling strategies. One ideal option is total recovery, a strategy in which all soil excavated from the site is sieved, and the sieves are scanned for animal bone and shell, which are removed and retained in a bag that represents that stratigraphic excavation unit. Because this involves sieving large quantities of soil, typically only screens with large mesh sizes—such as 1-centimeter or ¼-inch (or 6.35-millimeter) mesh—are used. The problem with this mesh size is that small bones, especially those of fish, can pass through the mesh and thus be artificially absent from the material analyzed. Finer mesh sizes are needed at sites with small organisms (e.g., amphibians, fish, rodents) to ensure that the bones recovered are representative of the original distribution of size classes among bones in the archaeological context. An alternative strategy is to coarse-sieve all sediments, but every fifth or tenth bucket of soil removed from the excavation must then be dry-sieved with a fine mesh or wet-sieved to more easily remove the adhering soil that can catch in the mesh.



Dry-sieving archaeological sediments with a coarse mesh; Fiji.

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Wet-sieving an archaeological sample with a fine mesh; Spain.

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